

Paul's Five Visits to Jerusalem

A timeline keyed to Galatians 1:18–2:10, with Acts cross-references, the missionary journeys, and the date of writing

Before Visit 1 — Conversion and Damascus

c. A.D. 34 — Paul is converted near Damascus (Acts 9:1-19). He goes to Arabia, returns to Damascus and preaches there, then escapes over the city wall in a basket when a plot forms against him (Acts 9:23-25; Gal. 1:17).

The Five Visits

Numbered entries are the five Jerusalem visits; the purple side-bar entries mark the missionary journeys and the writing of Galatians for context.

1. Post-Conversion Visit — c. A.D. 37

Gal. 1:18-20 / Acts 9:26-28

Three years after his conversion. Goes up to Jerusalem, sees Peter, stays fifteen days; also sees James the Lord's brother.

Between Visits 1 and 2, c. A.D. 37–46 (Gal. 1:21 / Acts 9:29-30): Still in Jerusalem, Paul disputes with the Hellenists, who seek to kill him. The brothers take him down to Caesarea and send him to Tarsus — the “regions of Syria and Cilicia” of Gal. 1:21 (Tarsus is in Cilicia). He remains there until Barnabas later brings him to Antioch (Acts 11:25-26).

2. Famine Visit — c. A.D. 48

Gal. 2:1-10 / Acts 11:27-30

Fourteen years after his conversion. From Antioch, goes up with Barnabas and Titus to deliver famine relief; meets privately with James, Peter, and John; Titus is not compelled to be circumcised.

First Missionary Journey — c. A.D. 48–49 (Acts 13:1–14:28). Paul and Barnabas, sent out from Antioch, evangelize Cyprus and South Galatia (Pisidian Antioch, Iconium, Lystra, Derbe) — the churches Galatians is addressed to — then return to Antioch.

Galatians Written — c. A.D. 49 Written from Antioch shortly after the first missionary journey and before the Jerusalem Council — Paul's earliest letter. This early date is why his sworn list of Jerusalem visits (1:20) can still stop at the famine visit: the Council simply hadn't happened yet.

3. Jerusalem Council Visit — c. A.D. 49–50

Acts 15:1-30 (not mentioned in Galatians)

Settles the law/grace dispute over circumcision — after the events of Gal. 2.

Second Missionary Journey — c. A.D. 50–52 (Acts 15:36–18:22). Paul, Silas, and later Timothy revisit the Galatian churches, then push into Macedonia and Achaia (Philippi, Thessalonica, Berea, Athens, Corinth) before returning to Antioch by way of Jerusalem.

4. End of Second Missionary Journey — c. A.D. 52

Acts 18:22 (not mentioned in Galatians)

A brief stop; greets the church, then returns to Antioch.

Third Missionary Journey — c. A.D. 53–57 (*Acts 18:23–21:16*). Paul strengthens the churches of Galatia and Phrygia, spends roughly three years at Ephesus, then travels through Macedonia and Achaia before sailing for Jerusalem.

5. Final Visit — c. A.D. 57–62

Acts 21:15–23:35 (not mentioned in Galatians)

Arrested in the temple, c. A.D. 57; two years in Caesarea (c. 57–59), followed by two years in Rome (c. 60–62).

Key point: In Gal. 1:20 Paul swears an oath that he has listed every Jerusalem visit up to that point in time. His sworn account only allows for Visits 1 and 2 — so the meeting he describes in Gal. 2:1–10 must be the famine visit (c. A.D. 48), not the Council (c. A.D. 49–50). The Council hadn't happened yet.

Dates are approximate and follow a common conservative chronology; scholars vary by a year or two at several points.